

The Badge System — Design Document

Fit Passport · prestige layer · design rationale and specification

A badge is not a sticker. It is a claim about a person, made in metal, that the person cannot buy — only earn. This document explains why the system exists, the principles that govern how every medal looks, the full ladder as built today, and — with no regard for production cost — how the medals *should* be made if the only constraints were the founder's: **restrained, refined, never gaudy.**

1. Why badges exist at all

The sizing engine is the reason a person *arrives*. It is not, by itself, a reason to *return* — once you know your size in a brand, that job is done. Products that last in apparel last on **ecosystem**, and an ecosystem needs a reason to contribute: to log honest fit ratings, to answer a stranger's question, to post a look. The badge system is that reason.

Its single design constraint governs everything below:

Status must be earned, never bought, and never faked.

Every badge is derived from *real* data — items you actually logged, answers other people actually found useful, likes your looks actually drew. There is no store, no shortcut, no cosmetic tier. That is what makes a badge worth showing, and it is why the passport card takes its finish from your highest earned metal: the card is a *summary of a claim you can defend*.

2. The five design principles

I. Rank must be legible in one glance. A ladder that needs a legend has failed. Metals get *further apart* as they climb — not a smooth gradient but a set of unmistakable materials (see §4). This is why platinum was retired: its pale cool grey sat too close to silver two rungs below, and a viewer couldn't tell rank from across a table. Titanium replaced it precisely because it is *unmistakable*.

II. Depth is real, not painted. A medal that is a flat disc with a gradient "skin" reads as a coin sticker. Ours have genuine relief — a struck field, a raised rim, a beveled edge, a contact shadow, and physical thickness you can see when you turn them. The medallion is dimensional at rest and rotates under the cursor; clicking lifts it onto an inspect stage that extrudes its *actual silhouette* in WebGL.

UPDATE 2026-08-25: list views now render a FLAT medallion by default — the dimensional build cost ~140 composited layers on the trophy case and was too heavy on lower-powered machines — so the

dimensional treatment lives in the inspect stage. The original intent, and the reasoning below, are unchanged and restoring it is one prop (BadgeCoin dimensional). Previously there was deliberately no flat variant anywhere in the product.

III. Ornament escalates; taste does not. Every badge carries a finish value from 0 to 5. Low tiers are plain struck tokens with a faint sheen. High tiers gain deeper relief, an engraved guilloché field, a double bevel, and — at the very summit — a laurel that overflows the rim. But even the top medal is *restrained*. More prestige buys more depth and more precision, never more noise.

IV. Every mark means something. No badge is decorated at random. Each track has a silhouette drawn from how craft actually frames rank (a heraldic shield, a guild mark), and each medal carries a **motif** — a real object from textile and dress history (a Roman fibula, a Jacquard loom, a bone sewing needle 40,000 years old). The art carries meaning, so a holder who reads the lore learns something.

V. One object, everywhere. The badge on the passport, in the community directory, on a public profile, and in the help gallery is the *same* object with the *same* behaviour. Consistency is itself a mark of quality; a badge that looked premium in one place and cheap in another would undermine the whole claim.

3. Structure — tracks, tiers, and capstones

The system has two parts: four **progression tracks** that give everyone a ladder to climb, and a set of **rare capstones** that sit above the tracks and are genuinely hard to reach. Scarcity is the point of the second part.

The four tracks (bronze → silver → gold → titanium)

TRACK	WHAT IT REWARDS	SILHOUETTE	WHY THIS SHAPE
The Wardrobe	Building a real, organised closet	Heraldic shield	A shield is what you build and defend — the base of an identity
The Fit Record	Honest fit outcomes logged over time	Round seal	The oldest form of a certified record; a struck civic seal
The Atelier	Posting looks the community responds to	Flat-top hexagon	Engineered, crafted, made — reads as construction
The Counsel	Answering others usefully	Quatrefoil guild mark	The four-lobed mark a workshop stamped on work it stood behind

The Counsel is deliberately the **hardest track to fake**, because it needs *other people* to find you useful — you cannot grind it alone.

The rare capstones (above the ladder)

CAPSTONE	METAL	HOW IT'S EARNED
Acclaimed	Diamond	250+ likes on a single look
Tastemaker	Amethyst (<i>special</i>)	1,500+ total likes across your looks
Polymath	Jade (<i>special</i>)	Gold or above in all four tracks
Head Designer	Obsidian	4,000+ total likes — the pinnacle

Capstones use a **rosette** — a scalloped medal edge reserved for honours that don't belong to any single track.

4. The metal ladder — colour and material

Colour is where rank is read, so the palette is designed for *distance between neighbours*, not smoothness. Each metal is specified as a six-stop material (highlight, mid, shadow, rim, engraving ink, ambient glow) so the SVG can light it like a struck surface rather than fill it like a shape.

METAL	RANK	CHARACTER	THE READING IT GIVES
Bronze	1	Warm, matte, low relief	"You've started. This is real."
Silver	2	Bright, cool, clean specular	Competent, everyday achievement
Gold	3	Warm yellow, high specular	Mastery within a track
Titanium	4	Mid-dark, violet-warm, brushed	Aerospace-grade; the top of a track
Diamond	capstone	Glassy, pale cyan, agate veining	A single brilliant achievement
Obsidian	pinnacle	Near-black volcanic glass	Rare, dark, exacting — the summit
Amethyst	special	Gem violet with white veining	Sets the taste (once valued with diamond)
Jade	special	Imperial green, agate veined	Breadth across everything
Amber	special	Fossil-orange, warm	Reserved for commemorative honours

Why titanium, not platinum. Platinum's colour was a pale cool grey — almost the same value and temperature as bright silver two rungs below it. On a passport card at banner size, a viewer genuinely could not tell them apart, which defeats Principle I. Titanium is **mid-dark and violet-warm with a brushed grain**: against bright silver, yellow gold, and glassy obsidian it is instantly its own thing. It also carries the right cultural association — the material of watch cases, aircraft, and surgical tools: *earned through engineering, not bought for show*.

Agate veining. Diamond and above gain irregular white veins, authored as hand-drawn curves in a unit box and clipped to the medal body — the striations of real agate, or the inclusions in a cut stone.

It signals "this is a rare material," and it only ever appears at the top, so it can never be mistaken for a lower tier.

5. The current medals, in full

Everything below is *built and live*. Thresholds are intentionally hard — a ladder that everyone maxes out in a week rewards nothing.

The Wardrobe — shield

- **Verified Closet** · bronze · 8+ garments logged · *motif: a hanger*. "Every archive begins with a first inventory."
- **Curator** · silver · 20+ items across 4+ collections · *motif: guardaroba shelves*. The Renaissance keeper of a well-ordered wardrobe.
- **Wardrobe Archivist** · gold · 45+ items across 10+ brands · *motif: an imperial silk archive*.
- **Grand Wardrobe** · titanium · 100+ items, 20+ brands, 6+ collections · *motif: an obelisk*. Scale that must be administered, not merely owned.

The Fit Record — round seal

- **Truth-Teller** · bronze · 5+ fit outcomes recorded · *motif: a Roman wax tablet*. The honest ledger of what fit and what didn't.
- **Calibrated** · silver · 25+ comfort refreshes · *motif: a sundial's gnomon*. Measurement kept true as the body changes.
- **Open Closet** · gold · listed publicly with a substantiated closet · *motif: a cartographer's compass rose*.
- **Fit Scholar** · titanium · 60+ refreshes and 20+ outcomes · *motif: a surveyor's rod*.

The Atelier — hexagon

- **First Look** · bronze · posted your first outfit · *motif: a bone needle, the oldest tool of dress*.
- **Stylist** · silver · 6 outfits posted · *motif: the tailor's shears*.
- **Couturier** · gold · 15 outfits and 150+ likes · *motif: the Jacquard loom*.
- **Atelier Master** · titanium · 30 outfits and 500+ likes · *motif: a maison's head atelier*.

The Counsel — quatrefoil

- **Sounding Board** · bronze · answered 3 questions · *motif: a thimble* — the humblest tool, the one that protects the hand doing the work.
- **Trusted Voice** · silver · 10 answers, 8 voted helpful · *motif: the tailor's tape*.
- **Fit Oracle** · gold · 30 answers, 40 helpful, 3 accepted · *motif: a medieval guild mark*.
- **Community Pillar** · titanium · 80 answers, 150 helpful, 12 accepted · *motif: the Roman fibula* — the clasp that held the whole garment together.

Rare capstones — rosette

- **Acclaimed** · diamond · 250+ likes on one look.
 - **Tastemaker** · amethyst · 1,500+ total likes.
 - **Polymath** · jade · gold in all four tracks — breadth, not just depth.
 - **Head Designer** · obsidian · 4,000+ total likes — the pinnacle.
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6. If cost were no object — the ideal medal

The brief: *most creative, most beautiful, most fashionable, most artful — while staying simple, restrained, and never gaudy.* Here is how each medal would be made if difficulty and cost did not exist and only that taste governed.

6.1 The material would be lit, not filled

A real struck medal has no "colour" — it has a **material under a light**. The ideal build renders every medal with a physically-based surface: a measured index of refraction per metal, anisotropic brushing on titanium that catches the light in a single direction, true Fresnel rim-light so the edge glows where it turns away from you, and a studio environment reflected in the field (a soft key, a cool fill, one hard rim). Turning the medal would sweep a real specular highlight across a real surface — the way you tilt a coin under a lamp to read it. *We already do a restrained version of this in the inspect stage; the ideal makes it the default everywhere, at a fraction of the intensity so it never shouts.*

6.2 The silhouette would be quieter and more precise

Fashion-world restraint means **fewer lines, cut exactly**. The ideal silhouettes drop every decorative flourish and keep one confident geometric gesture each:

- **The Wardrobe** — not a literal heraldic shield but its *essence*: a single tapered plane, like a garment bag seen edge-on, with one fold of relief.
- **The Fit Record** — a perfect circle with a single engraved concentric ring, the way a spirit level or a lens is machined. Precision *is* the ornament.
- **The Atelier** — the hexagon, but softened to the proportions of a spool end, with the six edges chamfered so light breaks differently on each.
- **The Counsel** — the quatrefoil reduced to four tangent circles, a knot, so it reads as *connection* rather than decoration.

6.3 The centre would be a single deep-relief mark

Not an icon sitting *on* the surface — a form **struck into** it, with the metal piled up at the edges of the stroke the way a real die displaces material. One motif per medal, drawn as a continuous line with no fill, catching a hairline of highlight on its raised edge and a pool of shadow in its valley. The motifs stay as they are — they already carry real meaning — but they'd be *sculpted*, so the thimble, the fibula, the loom read as objects you could run a thumbnail across.

6.4 Colour would be almost monochrome — until it isn't

The most fashionable, most "high" version of this system is **nearly achromatic**. Bronze, silver, gold, titanium, obsidian are all rendered as *tones of metal* — the whole ladder could sit on a black card and read as jewellery, not as a video-game loot table. The colour restraint is what makes the three **special** metals (amethyst, jade, amber) land: after a wall of disciplined greys and warm neutrals, a single veined violet or imperial green *means* something. Rarity you can see.

6.5 Motion would be the luxury signal

Cheap things flash. Expensive things move slowly and settle. The ideal medal drifts almost imperceptibly at rest (a fraction of a degree, as if breathing), turns with weight and a touch of inertia when you push it, and settles rather than snaps. The raking light tracks the rotation so the surface *tells you it is metal* without a single sparkle. This is exactly the note the K95 / NOTHIN' sites hit — first-second impact — but paid for in **material and motion**, not in loaders and wait time.

6.6 The set would be designed as a set

The final, most artful move: the eight metals and five silhouettes are designed as **one coherent family**, the way a fashion house designs a hardware collection — the same rim profile, the same bevel angle, the same light rig across all twenty medals, so that laying them out together looks like a *jewellery case*, not a sticker sheet. Coherence at the set level is the difference between "achievements" and "a collection." That is the bar.

7. Anti-patterns — what this system refuses to do

- **No purchasable tiers.** The moment status can be bought, it stops being status.
- **No rainbow.** More colours would read as a game UI. The ladder is metal; colour is spent only on the three rare specials.
- **No flat fallback.** A flat badge would break Principle II the instant it appeared next to a dimensional one.
- **No sparkle, no burst, no confetti.** Restraint is the brand. Prestige is shown with depth and precision, not with particle effects.
- **No fake data.** The founder/demo account can *display* the full ladder for a pitch, but even then the underlying stats stay honest — nothing about the engine or the leaderboards is distorted.

Implementation lives in `app-web/src/lib/badges.ts` (the ladder and thresholds — the single source of truth), `src/components/BadgeMedalLion.tsx` (the struck-metal SVG art, palette, silhouettes, and veining), `src/components/BadgeCoin.tsx` and `BadgeInspect.tsx` (the dimensional coin and the turn-to-inspect stage), and `src/components/MetalCard.tsx` (the passport card finish that follows your highest metal).